

Sometimes, a large block of ice was placed in the compartment and replenished at stations or scented jute mats, frequently splashed with water, were attached to windows to cool the carriages. Electric fans were introduced in 1905.

The Government did put in place some rules to improve third-class travel. As early as 1854, railway companies had been prohibited from selling more tickets than the space available in its rolling stock. In 1864, instructions were given to paint the permissible number of passengers outside the carriages. Besides low fares suggested to popularize railway travel among the masses, companies were also asked to allow third-class passengers to disembark at stations. Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi's journeys across India in third-class compartments brought the problems front and centre when he wrote about them, but progress was slow. It wasn't until post-Independence that the plight of 97 per cent of the total train travellers in India was given more thought.

“... [passengers were] huddled and crowded like cattle into carriages often unprovided even with seats.”

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